

A

Religious Tract,

RECOMMENDING

A CHRISTIAN'S DUTY

MOST RESPECTFULLY,

To the Parishioners

OF

ORTON ON THE HILL & TWYCROSS,

IN THE COUNTY OF LEICESTER.

BY THE REV. JOSEPH PHILLIMORE,

VICAR OF ORTON ON THE HILL.

ATHERSTONE :

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Religious Tract, &c.

NOTHING can be of more moment to you, than living virtuously on earth, as the salvation of your souls in future is one of the objects nearest my heart.

May you practise this friendly admonition contained herein, being assured I wish no harm or evil to any part of the human race, but for the love of my Redeemer, and the certain hopes of mankind zealous in faith and good works being rewarded with perpetual bliss, which the wicked and the negligent in pure religion will not inherit, unless they be reclaimed, and walk in newness of life, like the good and faithful which will produce repentance, and forgiveness from past sins, is the only object of my addressing this small tract of religion for your future private and public conduct.

It is almost ten years since my late most invaluable friend, John Randolph, late bishop of London, Bangor, and Oxford, in the year 1804, conferred on me an everlasting monument of friendship (which had existed unshaken more than thirty years), in presenting me to the living of Orton on the Hill; and with tributes of gratitude I daily looked upon it my bounden duty to have prayed for him during his life, and for the benefit of his surviving widow and family, for their present and future happiness; knowing you cannot be displeased at my imitating such a great example of Christianity, to invite you to pursue the blessed steps of a merciful Redeemer, who came into the world to save miserable lost sinners.

It was my first inquiry to know your characters and circumstances individually, and having minutely watched and observed your actions, though not extreme to mark what has been done amiss, I will allow there has been great improvement in general in religious exercises since my first appearance among you. Some exceptions there are, and I am fearful ever will be; there being scarce any flock without some wandering sheep; yet

happy should I be, if both my parishes were more exemplary in temperance, integrity, religion, and chastity, than any others in the diocese of Lincoln; but remember, those who have been exceptions, I have gently warned them of their errors and manner of life, privately at home, as well as in the church, to turn from their evil ways, and live; for why should the obstinate sinner practise bad habits, which will ruin both body and soul, instead of being forgiven by a merciful God, on hearty sorrow and repentance?

In the first place, I shall recommend private prayers, morning and evening, to you in your respective dwellings, that God may bless your industrious, honest endeavours, in this life with prosperity, and patiently to bear adversity.

In the morning, the first thing you think on, think on your God that made you, and his Son Jesus Christ, who redeemed the whole world from sin, and upon your bended knees offer up these two following prayers, and when finished, rise up and say your belief; and ye that are parents, teach them your children before you go to your daily labour.

Let (me or us) pray.

OUR Father, which art in heaven, hallowed be thy name: Thy kingdom come: Thy will be done in earth, as it is in heaven: Give us this day our daily bread, and forgive us our trespasses, as we forgive them that trespass against us; and lead us not into temptation, but deliver us from evil; for thine is the kingdom, the power, and the glory, for ever and ever. Amen.

O Lord, our heavenly Father, almighty and everlasting God, who hast safely brought (*us or me*) to the beginning of this day; defend (*us or me*) in the same with thy mighty power; and grant that this day (*I or we*) fall into no sin; neither run into any kind of danger; but that all (*my or our*) doings may be ordered by thy governance, to do always that is righteous in thy sight, through Jesus Christ our Lord. Amen.

Stand up to repeat your Belief.

I believe in God the Father almighty, maker of heaven and earth; and in Jesus Christ his only Son our Lord, who was conceived by the Holy Ghost, born of the Virgin Mary, suffered under Pontius Pilate, was crucified, dead, and buried; he descended into hell; the third day he rose again from the dead, he ascended into heaven, and sitteth on the right hand of God the Father almighty: from thence he shall come to judge the quick and the dead.

I believe in the Holy Ghost; the holy Catholic church; the communion of saints; the forgiveness of sins; the resurrection of the body, and the life everlasting. Amen.

Evening Prayers before going to bed.

OUR Father, which art in heaven, hallowed be thy name: Thy kingdom come: Thy will be done in earth, as it is in heaven: Give us this day our daily bread, and forgive us our trespasses, as we forgive them that trespass against us: and lead us not into temptation; but deliver us from evil; for thine is the kingdom, the power, and the glory, for ever and ever. Amen.

ALMIGHTY God, unto whom all hearts be open, all desires known, and from whom no secrets are hid; cleanse the thoughts of our hearts by the inspiration of thy Holy Spirit, that we may perfectly love thee, and worthily magnify thy holy name, through Christ our Lord. Amen.

LIGHTEN our darkness, we beseech thee, O Lord; and by thy great mercy defend us from all perils and dangers of this night, for the love of thy only Son, our Saviour, Jesus Christ. Amen.

After this private domestic duty to Almighty God, morning and evening, I should hope with such preparations, no one will be deficient in public duty every revolving Sabbath in God's holy church, to enable him to become as perfect a Christian as possible on earth; for private prayer is only one part of a Christian's duty; to which must be added, public devotion, praise, gratitude, and thanksgiving, for daily benefits received from Almighty God, on the sacred Sabbath. Private prayer without public devotion is imperfect,

like faith without works of charity, benevolence, and Christian love will not complete the true disciple of our Lord, like unto St. John; but an union of faith and good works daily practised will plead for mercy, and a resurrection from the dead to endless happiness.

Our excellent church requires three necessary offices to be observed, besides public worship, as preparatory to our Saviour's interference for miserable sinners:—Baptism, Confirmation, receiving the holy Sacrament frequently, particularly on the sacred days which have a preface appointed to be read in the communion service, which are on the nativity of Christ, or Christmas-day, Easter-day, Whit-Sunday, Ascension-day, Trinity-Sunday.

Our blessed Saviour was born in a manger, on Christmas-day, to teach mankind humility; suffered death on the cross, on Good Friday, to teach patience and resignation in affliction, troubles, and death; rose again the third day from the dead on Easter Sunday, convincing all the world he had conquered sin and wickedness.

On Ascension-day, after his most glorious resurrection from the dead, he manifestly appeared to his Apostles; and in their sight, he ascended up into Heaven to prepare a place for faithful Christians.

On Whitsunday, he sent down his Holy Spirit, like a dove, upon the Apostles, teaching the way, the truth, and the light of the Gospel.

Trinity Sunday is observed as a total union of Father, Son, and Holy Ghost, in heaven.

It is my eager wish, for the great benefit of both parishes, as an encouragement to religion, and the regular practice of it, that a Bible, the Common Prayer Book, the Whole Duty of Man, was in every house. The opulent part of the parishes, I have every reason to believe, have some of these books, Bible, Common Prayer, (perhaps not the book called the Whole Duty of Man), but I earnestly entreat them to buy it. Seven or eight shillings will. It contains the whole duty of a Christian: it is divided and subdivided into several Sundays, and an excellent substitute for sermons; for if religious discourses are not written by orthodox divines educated at either of our Universities of Oxford and Cambridge, and well chosen for unlearned people to read, they sometimes urge the ignorant, for want of

such superior education, to dive into mysteries which they cannot unfold, and increase the number of dissenters, many of whom presume to be teachers, by law authority, though without divine authority, and add greatly to the number of fanatics, by which means the blind lead the blind, though perhaps without any original intention of mischief.

Our blessed Redeemer was no respecter of persons; he came to save the poor as well as the rich, both to be inheritors of the kingdom of heaven; and it is becoming the poor should practise religion, and join in the service on the sacred Sabbath; for which reason, it was my wish a Sunday School might be established in both parishes, which has been done, one of some years, from which great benefit has ensued; the other is in its infancy, but I hope it will flourish, and be as effectual to stop vice as the other; for the beginning of all evil in general proceeds from neglect of early duty on the sacred Sabbath; but the future advantages of this institution must be considered, as well as the present; for after the children have learnt to read, and having no books, their parents being unable to purchase any, what will be the consequence? An oblivion of all their once acquired Christian duty? If some remedy is not prescribed, which I humbly recommend to all my wealthy parishioners to enter into, that the word of God may never be forgotten from infancy to old age, but cherished and nourished till the hour of death, as the most inestimable treasure, meriting the greatest future reward, and will never be forgotten by the almighty Disposer of all human events, when the humane and charitable will appear before him.

I recommend a Bible in every poor man's house, but this may be too expensive; but the one I shall offer will not; as I am a Member of the Society in London for propagating Christian Knowledge, I shall have an opportunity of purchasing the books at a reasonable rate; so as every poor man's house may have a Testament, Common Prayer, as I have the great satisfaction to assure my parishioners (of Orton), if the parents cannot read, the children can; by which means, whoever comes to church, may bring a prayer book, and join in the service, and the testament read at home.

I beseech you to listen to my entreaties for a subscription for the benefit of religion, and shew your permanent gratitude to the Almighty for his bountiful harvest; and likewise for the many great victories gained by our armies and our allies, in foreign countries, compelling the insulting tyrant

disgracefully to retreat with irreparable loss to his own country. But think, my parishioners, how this our native country, and united dominions, should excel all others in Europe in religion and gratitude, and give every token of present and future praise to the God of all mercies, who has so favourably defended us with his shield and buckler, never to have permitted the enemy's sword to be drawn in our land during the contest of 20 years.

Think on the thousands and thousands of innocent men, women, and children, who have fallen sacrifices, and our country has enjoyed inward tranquillity, peace, domestic and public.

There are thirty poor houses, for which I solicit from the farmers, as a token of gratitude, subscriptions which will enable me to fulfil my most eager desire for every family in the parish among the poor, to have a Testament and Common Prayer, by which means they will learn their duty to God and their neighbour.

The day is hastening (O my parishioners) when I shall meet you face to face, and our mutual examination will pass before a merciful and impartial Saviour and judge, to give an account of all our actions; when hypocrisy, intemperance, breaking the Sabbath and God's holy commandments, will receive their punishment, and virtue, religion, and charity, their rewards; for I have done my duty as a faithful shepherd, as far as my frail abilities have enabled me, to reclaim the wicked, and exhort the good, having clothed the naked, fed the hungry, visited the sick, and preached the blessed gospel of salvation to every one of you who have observed the sacred sabbath. When you have shut your pew doors, recollect, as many as possible, these verses of the Psalm xix. v. 14, 15. "Let the words of my mouth, and the meditation of my heart, be always acceptable in thy sight, O Lord, my strength and my Redeemer."

When the sermon is finished, before you go out of church, Psalm cxxxix. v. 23, 24. "Try me, O God, and search the ground of my heart, prove me, and examine my thoughts. Look well if there be any wickedness in me, and lead me in the way everlasting."

I remain,

Worthy parishioners,

Your constant well-wisher in things
temporal and eternal,

JOSEPH PHILLIMORE.
Vicar of Orton.

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